

What Happens When Grant Decisions Are Verified Before Writing Begins

A cohort model for capacity-building foundations and intermediaries

THE PROBLEM

The gap between AI adoption and grant outcomes

After capacity-building programs end, grantees return to the same decision process. AI finds more grants faster. No one verifies fit before writing begins.

60-80% of grants pursued by small nonprofits have at least one hard disqualifier that could have been caught before writing started.

The cost is invisible until the cycle closes: staff hours committed to ineligible applications, funder relationships damaged by ill-fitting proposals, board credibility tied to decisions that were never verified.

Capacity-building programs build grant writers. They do not change what happens before writing begins: the moment a grantee decides which grant to pursue. That decision is where the outcome is set. Everything after it is downstream.

THE COHORT MODEL

How verification works across a portfolio

COHORT STRUCTURE

- 15-25 organizations per cohort
- Bounded cohort (one grant cycle)
- Every active grant verified before writing begins
- Output: Board-ready Portfolio Impact Brief

VERIFICATION FLOW



WHAT GETS CHECKED

- Eligibility requirements (actual RFP, not summaries)
- Funder award history (IRS 990 records)
- Organization size and geography fit
- Timing and cycle status
- Relationship patterns

Not inferred. Verified against primary source records.

SAMPLE OUTCOME

Cohort outcome: Regional workforce development intermediary

Anonymized. One grant cycle. 22 organizations.

ORGANIZATIONS IN COHORT	22
TOTAL GRANTS SCREENED	87
GRANTS ELIMINATED BEFORE WRITING	51 (59%)
HARD DISQUALIFIERS CAUGHT	34
SOFT DISQUALIFIERS CAUGHT	17
ESTIMATED STAFF HOURS PROTECTED	1,200+
GRANTS THAT PROCEEDED TO WRITING	36
VERIFIED FIT CONFIRMED	28 of 36

Hard: eligibility, geography, budget floor | Soft: relationship required, cycle closed, funder pattern mismatch

"We funded six organizations to build grant-writing capacity. At our year-end review, we discovered two of them had spent combined 140+ hours on grants they were never eligible for. The time was gone and we hadn't protected it."

Capacity-building director, regional intermediary

THE DELIVERABLE

What your foundation receives

The Portfolio Impact Brief

A board-ready document that answers the accountability question your funders will ask: what did your capacity-building investment produce this cycle?

01 Applications screened before time was spent

Total grants verified across the cohort, with outcomes for each.

02 Hours redirected to viable grants

Quantified staff time protected from ineligible applications.

03 Failure patterns across the cohort

Most common disqualifiers: geography, budget floor, relationship, timing.

04 Documented decision improvements

Comparison against previous cycle or baseline, where available.

05 Board-ready format

Formatted for board presentation or funder reporting. No additional work required.

When your funders ask what your capacity-building dollars produced this cycle -- this is the answer.

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Verification-First Grant Intelligence



*This runs inside the active grant cycle.
Not after. Not next quarter.*

Prepared for:

[Foundation / Association Name]

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